Importantly, the Modi-Trump meeting saw the signing of the US-India COMPACT (Catalyzing Opportunities for Military Partnership, Accelerated Commerce & Technology), with a results-driven agenda. It included negotiating a new Bilateral Trade Agreement (BTA) by the fall of 2025 with a "bold new goal" for Mission 500 that aimed to double total bilateral trade to $500 billion by 2030. They agreed on a framework for a defence partnership for the US to sell the state-of-the-art 'Javelin' Anti-Tank Guided Missiles and 'Stryker' Infantry Combat Vehicles to India in a new co-production arrangement. Trump even offered the US Air Force's top-of-the-line F-35 fighter jets at the joint press conference. The two countries had all bases covered when they inked a strategic technology agreement to collaborate on critical and emerging technologies in areas like AI, semiconductors and quantum computing and be part of the global supply chain for rare earth minerals needed for hi-tech.

The MAGA Influence

However, despite the promising start, Indo-US ties began going downhill soon after the summit. This was due to several reasons, some having to do with India's assumptions based on its dealings with Trump 1.0, and others concerning Trump himself. Professor Sumit Ganguly, senior fellow at the Hoover Foundation at Stanford University, says, "When it comes to dealing with Trump, you can throw out all the grand international relations theories we teach in universities and explain US policy through only one variable: Trump's personality. Everything is transactional: You scratch my back and I scratch yours."

Experts like India's former national security advisor Shivshankar Menon are dismissive of the view in some circles that India is dealing with two Washingtons: one driven by a fickle Trump who blows hot and cold frequently, and the other by the Establishment that stands steadfastly with India. His perception: "There is no meaningful divide between, say, the Pentagon and the White House. The world has accepted that it is now living in Trump's world, whether it likes it or not. We are dealing with a fundamentally different United States, where protectionism and isolationism are no longer deviations, but the norm." Interestingly, Menon believes the shift reflects the longer-term movement away from liberal globalism that began before Trump.

Many experts agree with Menon, but argue that Trump has merely weaponised the political and cultural anxieties of his MAGA base, which largely comprises White Christian nationalists who perceive a loss of dominance and identity. Columnist and author Tom Friedman believes that America may be headed toward a third civil war—one distinct from the first, which pitted North against South, and the second, which centred on racial rights. This time, he argues, conflict would be driven by disputes over identity, belonging, nationalism and fundamental cultural values.

Trump is also unconstrained in unprecedented ways compared to his first term. He is not hemmed in by the establishment or by legislators, has presidential immunity from prosecution and urgently wants to get things done before the next round of Congressional elections. An American expert cautions against over-reading Trump's perceived personal friendship with Modi, saying, "Though



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— Shivshankar Menon, *Former NSA*